



Friendly visit

A Green Beret laughs with Montagnards in the Central Highlands. Special Forces visited villages to forge relationships—drinking rice wine and learning about the tribes' music, traditions, and weapons.

Special qualities

The Green Berets established good relationships with their new allies. The collaboration became a bright spot in what was often a confusing and frustrating war. "The Yards," one Green Beret was reported as saying, "are easy to get along with."

The Montagnards were quick to demonstrate their bravery. In June 1962, for example, village defenders in the Sedang tribal area repelled a Viet Cong attack armed only with knives and bows and arrows. That October, when Viet Cong shot down Captain Terry D. Cordell's aircraft in full view of the CIDG strike force he was advising in Buon Enao, the Rhade were so enraged by his loss that they turned on the Viet Cong and drove them off in disorder.

With help from the US Navy's Seabees, the Green Berets constructed dams, roads, bridges, and schools for the Montagnards. They also dug wells and provided basic healthcare. The results confirmed the success of the cooperation. By December 1963, some 19,000 Montagnards had enrolled in part-time village militias, while 6,000 more were serving in CIDG strike forces, which stood ready to be airlifted to trouble spots.